



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with JM

Anonymous (JM)

March 2019

Location: JM's home in England

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Jack Crangle

Warning this transcript contains details of sexual abuse.

JM narrated details of an abusive childhood. Her father did not send JM to school, instead expecting her to work in the family business. JM was physically abused in the family home by her stepmother and her father. She was sexually assaulted at the age of 12 by an older teenager and, later, was sexually harassed by her grandmother's partner. At 15 she was sexually abused again by an older male and was left pregnant. The police and social services were involved and she was eventually sent to Thorndale House, the Salvation Army mother and baby institution in Belfast. JM planned to keep her baby although social workers encouraged her to consider adoption. Tragically, JM's baby died shortly after birth. She was due to give birth in Thorndale's maternity ward but was rushed to hospital as the baby was a breech birth. She is angered that she was never allowed to see her child, or hold him. Moreover, she was only given details of his burial plot after several years of requesting it. This aspect of her story particularly agitates JM and she is anxious to discover more about this strange set of circumstances and learn why details were withheld from her. After JM returned to Thorndale, without her baby, a vicar visited her. Instead of offering her some form of solace, he showed more disturbing interest in the sexual acts that had led to JM's pregnancy and she described him as a 'pervert'. JM went on to reflect on how these deeply traumatic experiences had impacted her relationships with men and also how they had motivated her to succeed in her career.

Names, dates and occupational details are redacted to ensure maximum anonymity for JM and others. Redactions are indicated by **.

OD: So I have both recorders on now. So, just for the tape, I'm Olivia Dee and I'm from Queen's University, and I've come to England to interview an anonymous interviewee about her experience. Can I just double check, it's Thorndale that you were..?

JM: That's right, yes.

OD: Yes, great. And you're happy to be recorded and...?

JM: Yes, I am.

OD: Fantastic. So if you see me fiddling, at either point, with these, it's only because I'm just [sound] checking levels. I'm still listening, nothing has stopped. Okay, great. So could you just tell me, first of all, what your connection is? So you were in Thorndale...

JM: If I tell you from the beginning...

OD: Yeah, I'm happy.

JM: So I was born in *NI location redacted* in *date in 1950s*.

OD: Okay.

JM: My mother was, and father were very young, and when I was eighteen months old, my mother left, and she left me with my father, and my father was abusive. And he never sent me to school. He, sort of, lived two years in Ireland, two years in England ...

JM: Two years in England, and whenever the authorities realised, someone would say: "Oh, there's a child, she's not at school." Because he kept me off to help him on his *occupational detail* round, because he had a van [that he did his rounds in]. They'd come, they'd get in touch and say: "This child should be at school", and then he would send me, he would go back to England or Ireland, and that's how it was. So I didn't get an education. So I was illiterate. And, so as I say, I never really knew my mother. And then, at the age of about thirteen, I no longer had contact with my father. What happened was, I was raped, and...

OD: By your father?

JM: No, no, well I don't know, because I have no memory of my childhood. So I, there was something there, but I have no, I don't remember anything, okay? And so I can never say. But I was raped by a young man who was, I was twelve and he was eighteen. And I have to say that worse than the rape was the, was the police examination. It was humiliating. And having to give an account of what happened in the police station, my father sitting behind me, was mortifying. And then, basically he, I had a stepmother who hated me because I looked like my mother, and she used to beat me round the head with shoes all the time, and prior to that my father had hit me, a blow to the face, and broken my nose and my, the bone had gone up and torn along into my brain. So when I was six, I had all these plates put in and, anyway. So anyway, at the age of

thirteen or so I was I was gone from there, shall we say? And I decided that I would make a life for myself. Sorry about this noise.

OD: At thirteen?

JM: Yes. But, and I went to stay with my grandmother. And, on and off through the years, my grandmother had been there for me, and she gave me self-esteem, self-worth, and made me feel like I was worth something and, that she'd not push me around. And she also would occasionally check me to make sure I hadn't any bruises or anything like that, she did that. And then, so what happened was, at the age of fifteen I found myself pregnant. And I'd never broken the law or been in trouble, I'd never had an education, and the father of the child was much, much ,older than me, and he was arrested by the police, because he had some sort of credit card problem or something, he was doing some sort of credit card scam.

OD: Okay.

JM: And I was taken to the police station in Ireland, and when they realised, he'd said that I was older and stuff like that, and then they realised I was only fifteen and I was pregnant, there was a police officer there, she was very, very nice to me, She really looked after me. She took me home that night, she washed my clothes, she let me stay in hers, and then social services came along. Social services took me and they put me into a borstal¹ because they didn't have any room in a mother and baby home. I can't remember the name of the borstal, but, so they locked me up. And then they came along and said that, because my father would not provide anything for me, they would have to take me into care.

¹ Possibly Whiteabbey Training School.

While I was in that borstal I had to clean floors with wire wool on my hands and knees, while I was pregnant. We did attend classes. The teachers were quite nasty pieces of work and so were the people that ran these places. And the teacher would constantly say: "You're gonna end up pushing a pram with no future and no nothing." Nobody ever, really, sort of tried to help me with being illiterate or anything like that. Anyway, I'm just skirting over what's, what hap ...

OD: Yeah.

JM: ...what went on. Yeah, okay.

OD: Carry on.

JM: So, while I was in that home, they, I was sitting, my back was hurting one day, I was pregnant, you know, and I have to just say, I did nothing wrong, I'd never broken the law. To this day I have never broken the law, I've never been in trouble with the police.

OD: Yeah.

JM: You know, I'm a good citizen. And the, one of the women said to me: "Oi you, sit up". and I said: "I can't, my back's killing me."

And she said to me: "You'd think you were carrying a dog instead of a child." And I was really annoyed so I gave her a mouthful. They locked me in a room with a potty and a mattress for two days, okay? So I was confined. Anyway, eventually social services came along and they said they could move me to Thorndale. And they put me in Thorndale and it was, it was really quite traumatic, because I was very young. The other girls were actually older than

me, and I was very, very young, very nervous, and I'd sort of end up in a dorm. I mean, I'm just telling you what I can remember, I can't remember everything.

OD: Yeah, no, but I mean, to, to be fifteen in that situation, anyway, must've been very, very terrifying.

JM: Very, yeah. So, so you just get on with it. I'm quite a strong character and, you know, so you just get on with it. Anyway, I settled in to Thorndale and they didn't really have a lot to do with us really, the Salvation Army were in running the place. We were examined by a doctor. They delivered babies at Thorndale, and the social services kept coming to me and asking if I would have my baby adopted, and I said no. I refused, I wasn't gonna have him adopted. Because I was a child that had never been nurtured, and no love in my life, obviously I wanted, I understand that now, I wanted that little baby so I could have something to love, yeah?

OD: Yeah absolutely.

JM: So they, they were, so I was there, and it was a funny situation because the soldiers used to come round to the windows of Thorndale in the evenings and be chatting to the girls. But they didn't realise they had these great big bumps, that they were pregnant, you know.

OD: And were these, which soldiers, these were...?

JM: British Army.²

² Possible British Army foot patrols. Girdwood Barracks was close to Thorndale.

OD: British Army.

JM: Yeah, British Army, yeah. And anyway, the doctors used to examine, and the doctor said to the people at the home: “She needs to go to the hospital because the baby’s breech, and he needs to be turned.”

OD: Yeah.

JM: So they took me to the hospital, and the hospital said: “No, no, no, that baby will turn. Everything is fine.” Or they said the baby had turned, I can’t actually remember which, okay?

OD: Yeah.

JM: And then I went back to the home, and they ... I, I went into labour. And this home was very, they didn’t really have anything to do with, we were just left to our own devices, we could come and go as we wanted. They didn’t really look after us. I think the thing that makes me angry is that social services didn’t give me an education when they realised I was illiterate.

OD: Yes, and that you were fifteen.

JM: And I feel they should’ve done, because they took me into care, therefore they were my parents.

OD: Yeah.

JM: Therefore they had a legal responsibility to give me some sort of an education. So, what happened was, I went into labour and I didn't know I was in labour, and I went to the matron and said: "I'm, I'm in pain."

"Don't be so stupid, the baby's head's not even engaged, go away!" [was the reply JM recalled].

So a few hours later I come back and said "I'm gonna throw myself off the roof, I'm in so much pain." She looked at me and she said: "Get in the car, we need to get the hospital now, that baby's coming breech now." So we got in the car...

OD: So it was still breech?

JM: Yes it was still breech, yeah. And we got in the car, and on the way there was a road block and all that sort of thing, and by the time we got to the hospital he was being born.

OD: Oooh, poor thing.

JM: And I, and I felt them cut me, okay. And I, all I know is, he came out and I looked, there was a nurse with a bobbed ginger hair looking at me, looking over me, and I said: "Where's my baby, where's my baby?" And she said: "Oh, we've had to take him, he's not very well." So they took him out of me and took him away without me seeing him or holding him. Anyway, they [JM becomes emotional]. Sorry, it's just so, that, that thing, that, not being able to hold him is just... Anyway, they sent me back to the home. Gave me no information at all. They ordered me out of that hospital back to the home.

OD: How – sorry, I'm really sorry to interrupt.

JM: It's alright.

OD: But I'm just, I want to make sure we get this. How long after giving, having...

JM: Instantly.

OD: So you had an episiotomy, they cut you.

JM: They cut me, yes.

OD: And they took the baby after a breech birth, and you went straight back to Thorndale.

JM: They took me straight back, yeah. Yeah. And they wouldn't allow me to see him. And they told me that he, he was, he had brain damage, that his head came down and the cord came down, and therefore he had severe brain damage. So I wasn't, so, that he wouldn't survive, that he was, he should be, he should be christened. So I christened him *name redacted*. So his name was *redacted* Anyway, five days later I got a phone call. I mean, the whole time I'm saying: "Listen, I want to go and see my baby. Please let me go and see my baby." And they just absolutely refused. Absolutely refused. No one came to see me, to counsel me, to talk to me about it except for a vicar.

OD: Yeah.

JM: Anyway, so what happened was, after five days they told me that he was dead and he had to be buried. And I went to the funeral, and it was a little white box, and I tried to open it to hold him, and two social workers physically restrained me from going near the box. They held me back by my arms. After

that a vicar came to see me, and I sat in a room, I remember it had a big bay window, at Thorndale, and the vicar sat one side of the room and I sat at the other. And he said to me “did you enjoy having sex? What position did you have sex in?” That’s all he asked me, just about...So, yeah, that was the vicar.

OD: So he just asked you...

JM: Yeah, he never said to me, you know, anything religious or nothing. He just wanted to know whether, whether I enjoyed the sex and what position I’d had it in.

OD: Why do...?

JM: He took complete advantage of me. I was in that room on my own.

OD: At fifteen.

JM: At fif-, well I was sixteen when the child was born. He was born the *date redacted*. And the funny thing is, all my babies were born on the *day of the month redacted*.

OD: Really?

JM: Different years, different months, every one of them on the *day of the month redacted*.

OD: Wow.

JM: Isn’t that strange?

OD: Yeah, I wonder what that means.

JM: It means this year's gonna be my year, because it's the *day of the month redacted*.

OD: Yes. So, just so we get this on tape, why do you think he was asking you that? Was...?

JM: Because he was a pervert.

OD: So it wasn't to make you feel ashamed or anything? It was for him.

JM: I've no idea, you tell me, I have no idea. I just sat there away from the man, I didn't wanna go near him. He said: "Oh, come and sit over here." And I was like "No way!"

OD: Oh, that's a position of trust isn't it? It's supposed to be, and you, you must've felt really exposed.

JM: Where was social services in all this?

OD: Yeah I'm really surprised.

JM: Where were social services? I wanna know – what I'd like to know out of all this – is, I would like to know, because there's a little bit more that's horrendous, but I'd like to know who said I couldn't see my son. Who said I couldn't hold him? Who said he was to be taken at birth like that without me having any, you know? Then afterwards I had kept asking them what the grave

number, what the grave number, but no, they never said it to me. So I can't remember, over yea-, over a period of years I contacted social services, probably about fifteen years ago or something like that, and demanded answers. And I got the grave number, and when they first went to Thorndale, Thorndale said there was no record of me ever being there, and the social worker went back and said: "Well, clearly that's not true because you buried her child; it's on the death certificate." You know?

OD: Yeah.

JM: So, yeah. And then what happened was I got myself a job in a printers .. And I, there was a really nice couple that had three children, and they offered me room and board in exchange for helping them with the children. So I did that. And then social services, I was at the printers a week, social services came along and said: "We're your parent", basically, "until you're eighteen you're in our charge. These people are not foster parents, so you can't stay here." So I said: "Well, where am I gonna go?"

OD: Yeah.

JM: And they said: "We're gonna put you back in the borstal because we don't have any room anywhere else." So they were gonna lock me up again. So the guy that owned the house said: "Have you got any money?" And I had eleven pounds wages, and he said: "Go and get your, your money", and he gave me some money, and he said "get on the ferry, go to England, don't let them lock you up, why should you?" I'd never broken the law, never done anything wrong.

OD: And had you, you'd sort of bounced around a bit anyway? You said your dad had brought you to England.

JM: My dad, back and forth back and forth with my dad, constantly.

OD: So where did you, where had he, sort of, taken you to? Was it, was there specific areas?

JM: *area in England redacted*.

OD: Oh okay.

JM: Yes, yes.

OD: So where, where were you gonna go on the ferry? Where was that?

JM: When I, when I left?

OD: Yeah.

JM: Oh I was going to go and look for my grandmother.

OD: Okay.

JM: Because she was in, she was her, in, in *location in England redacted*, I think it was.

OD: So did you...?

JM: ... Yeah and I, I found her, yes. Did I find her? Let me think. Yes I did. Did I? I can't remember. No, no. What happened was I met a soldier on the boat, on the ferry. And I went to *English city redacted* to stay with his family, we ended up getting married. Didn't last for long.

OD: Oh. How old were you?

JM: I was seventeen. Sixteen, seventeen.

OD: Did you need to lie about your age to get married?

JM: No. I had, I wrote to my father to get permission, and he gave permission.

OD: Oh, okay.

JM: So I was able to get married.

OD: So you got married in *name of English city redacted*?

JM: Yes, yeah. And it didn't last very long. It was, but I had another child. I had, so I started, my son, I had two, I never ever had another son, and I had two girls. So, and I have nightmares to this day, and it's the same recurring dream. And I dream that – and you have to remember that I'm *age redacted* now – that I dream that I wake up and there's, I open a drawer and there's a baby in the drawer. And it's, it's emaciated or it's starving, I've forgotten to look after it. So when people say that you can just get pregnant, lose the baby, and it doesn't affect you, it affects you for the whole of your life. So I don't know what else you want me to tell you really.

OD: Well I, I mean, the thing is, it's not, with stories like this it's really about what you're comfortable sharing.

JM: Yes.

OD: So if you, if you have more that you want to tell me then I'll listen to it.

JM: Well just that I won in the end, because I *details of JM's business redacted*. I, I was illiterate, when I was twenty-seven I met the love of my life, and he was, he immediately realised that I was bright and intelligent, so he helped me learn to read and write.

OD: Yeah.

JM: I became a *detail redacted*. I was one of the first ... in this country in the eighties.

OD: Oh wow.

JM: I then became a *occupational detail redacted* and did City and Guilds, that was such a big thing. Ran my own *detail redacted* business. And then I started *detail of business redacted* ... So that's, I made more money doing that than I ever did working. I worked for *name of retailer redacted*. I've just got a, a pension from *name of retailer redacted*, yeah. So I was a normal person. They had no reason to lock me up, and they'd no reason to treat me the way they did treat me. And I hate social services, because I think, so, I mean it would've been them that said: "She goes home" - out of the hospital - "and she doesn't get to see the child." Someone turned that machine off, you know, for him to die. I should've been involved in it.

OD: You should've been there.

JM: I should've been able to hold him.

OD: So can I ask you a couple of questions?

JM: Yeah, yeah, sure.

OD: Because I think a lot of what you said is, I just really want to make sure that we get it fully on record.

JM: Yeah, yeah.

OD: So can I ask, first of all, if I go back to the beginning, were your parents from Northern Ireland?

JM: Yes, yes.

OD: Okay.

JM: From *location redacted*, yeah.

OD: Great. And why, how, how did your father move you around? Did he have work, did he work abroad?

JM: He had, he was a *occupation redacted*.

OD: Okay.

JM: And he had a *occupation redacted* van. So he used to, he did different things. He sort of, like, yeah he, he went to all different jobs. At one point he was doing nights in a factory and he'd keep us, sort of, I had a half-sister, and he used to sort of lock us in the kitchen for the day or, you know, while he was working and stuff like that. It was horrendous, my stepmother was a pretty nasty piece of work. She used to beat me frantically. And the, you know, so I have a broken nose which can't be fixed, okay? Because I had a blow to the face.

OD: Yeah.

JM: I don't remember it, but I've got a scar across here and they won't fix my nose because it's so damaged inside. I've had to live that, with that all my life, knowing my father did that. And the reason I know my father did that is because my grandmother would never tell me the truth about it, and she'd only ever cover for her own son. And my stepmother abused me physically, and when I was thirteen I had a go back.

OD: Yeah.

JM: After the rape and the humiliation, it was their fault. I told them, I told them, one of the neighbours told them, this lad was following me all the time and, you know, they just took no notice and said it wasn't true and, you know. So...

OD: So who was this, this guy?

JM: I don't know. I don't know.

OD: So he just grabbed...

JM: Didn't know his, yeah, didn't know his name or anything, just grabbed, pulled me into a barn. I didn't know, I didn't really know, it was funny, in, in the police car on the way to the police station to make the statement, the policewoman said to me: "Did he have an erection?" And I was like: "I don't know what that is."

OD: Yeah.

JM: And I, and she, and my grandmother says, my stepmother sort of kneed, you know, sort of nudged me and said: "Of course you know what it is"... "I don't", I didn't know what it was. I was very sheltered, I was, I really didn't know.

OD: Yeah. So you'd, this had happened to you and you went back and you told your father and your stepmother what had happened?

JM: Yes, yes.

OD: And they called, they called the police?

JM: Yes.

OD: Okay, and then your experience of telling the police, was, was that difficult because you...

JM: My father was behind me.

OD: And you didn't want that?

JM: And I didn't really understand.

OD: Yeah, definitely.

JM: I didn't really understand.

OD: And also, I'm just wondering, was someone showing you, you said there was a policewoman who took care of you.

JM: No, no, the policewoman [who] took care of me, the policewoman that was nice to me and took care of me was at the, [was later] when I was with the father of the child and he was arrested.

OD: Oh, yeah, yeah, yeah.

JM: And she showed real kindness.

OD: Yes, okay. So what happened to you after you, after you reported your attack? You had to go back home and...?

JM: Yeah. Well I reported it, and I went to the police station and made a statement, I had to have a medical, and my stepmother was there. It was just so humiliating.

OD: And was the medical, was it humiliating?

JM: It was a medical police doctor, and it was horrendous.

OD: Was that because of his attitude or was that just because that, in general...?

JM: Because he was a male. Because I was embarrassed to hell. I was, you know, I was a young kid. I, Jesus it was terrible.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And, so that was really bad.

OD: And any kind of examination like that can just be so traumatic anyway if it's not, kind of, handled right. And I suppose, having someone there that you don't trust like your stepmother or your dad...

JM: Exactly.

OD: Yeah, I can really imagine that must've been terrible.

JM: Just, just horrendous. And not, and this man, and I'm...

OD: It seems weird that they would throw a man in there and not, not find you a woman.

JM: Well, then they didn't really care did they?

OD: And when was, this was ...?

JM: Well I was born *date in 1950s*.

OD: Yeah.

JM: ... in the ... early seventies.

OD: Yeah. So, and this was when you were twelve?

JM: It was, I'd just had my twelfth birthday.

OD: That's awful. So, when you get to thirteen...

JM: Sorry, so after that my dad can't even look at me. While my, while my, my stepmother was married to my dad, I was not allowed any physical contact with my father whatsoever. She wasn't, I wasn't allowed to sit on his knee. She, she had a child, a son, *name redacted*, and he had to pay all attention to *name redacted*. And there was no, I mean, as a little girl you love your dad, and if you're not allowed to go near him and then he's not allowed to show you any kindness or he's not allowed to cuddle you, it is horrendous. And she wouldn't allow it, she hated me. And I hate her. And the years of being beaten and having my head pushed up against the door and all sorts of things, and the way we were treated, I mean, we were treated like we were, it was horrendous, absolutely horrendous, you know. I, I had to wear clothes that my brother had been sick on, and they didn't wash us, and it was, it was pretty, pretty bad. It was an absolute abuse. And you know, and then one day he was lying on the sofa, and she went for me, and I was thirteen, and it was after the rape, and I just fought back.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And she was screaming: “Ah, get her off me, get her off me, she’s...” And he just ignored it, he knew it was happening.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And then it was: “You’ve gotta go.”

OD: So, so she kicked you out.

JM: They kicked me out, yeah, and they sent me to live with my grandmother.

OD: Oh yeah, of course.

JM: In *area in England redacted*. Which is where I, I met, because something else happened. God. I got to my grandmother’s...

OD: If you don’t want to tell me, you don’t have to. But you’re more than welcome to.

JM: Okay. So I got to my grandmother’s, and I had a grandfather that was my step-grandfather, who’d have known me since I was a little babe in arms anyway. My grandmother used to look after the old lady downstairs in return for us living upstairs in this quite big house. And my grandfather used to, well he used to expose himself to me constantly. And then one day he stood, he was a big man, he stood across the door – he never touched me – and he put his arm across the door and exposed himself, and I just knew, at that point, this, this has to stop. So I ran away.

OD: Okay.

JM: And I went to social services. And I told them. And they came back to the house and they said to my grandmother: “Apparently your husband is doing this.” And they said to me: “You’ve got a lock on your bedroom door, use it.” And I said: “But it’s not happening in the bedroom, it’s happening in the lounge when my Nan goes to bed.” And that was it.

OD: Wow.

JM: And my grandmother, I ran away, and my grandmother disowned him, and he [grandmother’s husband] died a few months after that. But she said: “I’ll never ever speak to him again.”

OD: So she believed you?

JM: She knew, yeah. She said: “You know, you”...

OD: I can see you...

JM: My grandmother absolutely idolised me, you know.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And she said: “I can’t believe that he would do anything like that”, she said, “but to do that when you, he’s had you since you was a little babe in arms, [I’ll] never forgive him for that.”

OD: It’s, oh, yeah, I mean I’m really glad you had that, at least that one influence, that woman who was...

JM: Well my grandmother was the one that, she used to say to me, well, you know: “You’re, you’re special. You’re not, don’t let them make you think that you’re not, you are special. You be proud. When you go out the door, make sure that you hold your head up, you make sure that you look good. There’s nobody better than you.” She gave me self-esteem.

OD: Yeah. And I think you need that at fif-, at fifteen, being a teenage girl is so hard anyway, and to have all of that piled on top of it, you need at least one voice, don’t you?

JM: Yeah.

OD: That’s gonna build you up.

JM: Yeah, you do. You really need someone who believes in you and says: “Oh, these are all....[sentence not finished]” So I was able to, I mean, years later, when I had my babies, I had some counselling, because I had my babies and I loved them, but there was something missing, there was something.

OD: Yeah.

JM: So I went and had some counselling, and because I’d never been nurtured as a child, apart from by my grandmother, I found it difficult. I would just, there was this feeling of, I was holding my babies but I wasn’t wholly comfortable with it, you know? So I went, and then I realised, they say that women that are abused, they will often not abuse their own children, they will seek help, because the maternal instinct is very powerful.

OD: Absolutely.

JM: ... So, yeah, so I think they, where was I? I can't remember.

OD: So you, you sought counselling after your daughters were born.

JM: Yes, yes, and they said that they wanted to ... so I felt more comfortable, I understood then, that because I hadn't been nurtured, it, I was finding it difficult. Not that I didn't love them, I loved them intensely.

OD: Oh but there's, there's a million things that can affect...

JM: Yes.

OD: ...That can affect you outside of that, it doesn't mean that you didn't love them.

JM: No, no, I did. And I looked after them with a vengeance.

OD: Yeah.

JM: But, I mean, I'm very lucky I have two gorgeous girls and I have four grandchildren. And my grandson is twenty. He was twenty on *date redacted* and he's, my kids are level-headed. They've never been in trouble with the police. They've never taken drugs. Well, I don't know, they've probably dabbled at some point that I didn't know about. So I'm very lucky that, you, know. But, so it was diff-, I started the counselling and then they said that they thought I should go into hospital and be hypnotised to bring out the stuff I don't remember from my childhood.

OD: Yeah, interesting.

JM: And I couldn't. Because I, I describe it as a 'lion in my chest' that wants to tear out. And they, I was told that if I had the counselling I might, and they put me under and do it, it might traumatise me to such an extent that I'd never quite be right again. So I decided, I decided, I think years ago, the best thing to do was, these people are nothing to do with me, this is not my life.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And make your own life.

OD: It sounds like that's exactly what you've done.

JM: Move on.

OD: Yeah, is you've picked what you, what you want. I think that's really brave, and it's very, it's very difficult to do, and you did it.

JM: Very, very difficult. Yeah, without, without guidance and without support. But, you know, social services are supposed to support you. Social services destroyed my life, you know. They're supposed to protect you. They didn't protect. You know, the Salvation Army, they didn't protect me or help me. You know. The vicar. And then, you know.

OD: Do you remember any of their names?

JM: No, no. And, of course, Thorndale is now saying they don't have any records, and then social services went back and said: "Well you must have a record because the burial, you know, you buried the child so you must have."

OD: Yeah, definitely.

JM: So...

OD: I'm really con-, not concerned, I'm very interested that we get this part right. First of all, that you had quite a difficult birth.

JM: Yes, with the breech.

OD: And that you were cut, which I think is a really...

JM: I was cut and I felt it.

OD: Yeah.

JM: I felt them cut me.

OD: But to then go back to Thorndale, rather than stay in the hospital.

JM: They didn't allow me to.

OD: Yeah, no I know, I'm just saying I think it's very important that we clarify that, because I'm wondering what kind of aftercare, like, physical aftercare you got.

JM: Well, Thorndale was supposed to, like, they bind my breasts.

OD: And did they give you Epsom salts or anything to stop...?

JM: I just remember them binding my breasts. When I had the stitches out Thorndale took them out.

OD: Really?

JM: Yes.

OD: So did they have midwives there, then, or doctors?

JM: Well, I don't know, these, these. There was one woman, the brigadier or whatever her name was, and she was supposed to be a midwife. She was delivering babies apparently.

OD: And the only reason that you had your baby in hospital is because it was breech?

JM: Yeah.

OD: And they said that it would...

JM: And they went: "Ooh no! It's got to go hospital." Yeah.

OD: So I'm wondering why, it seems like you were let down in healthcare, repeatedly from that pregnancy.

JM: Yes.

OD: And I'm just quite shocked that there was no, so they noticed it was breech and then they didn't do a check-up or anything beforehand. That seems quite neglectful to me.

JM: Yeah.

OD: Okay.

JM: They didn't really care, you know.

OD: Yeah.

JM: They weren't really, that wasn't really their focus.

OD: But, but I think what's difficult is that you're fifteen, sixteen, so you're not gonna know that. It's not, it's not like...

JM: And I'd nobody round me to tell me.

OD: Exactly. It's not that you're twenty-nine or you're...

JM: Exactly.

OD: ... Or you know, you know what questions to ask. It seems like you were in a very vulnerable position and no one told you anything.

JM: No one to help. No.

OD: And did you know what to expect from labour and from everything? So that was all a surprise and...?

JM: They didn't tell us anything. They didn't...

OD: So there was no education about what to expect.

JM: No. There was no education full stop.

OD: Yes.

JM: And I'm angry about that because social services should've made sure I had some sort of education, should've made sure I could learn to read and write. Why didn't they? I mean, that is a biggie. If they're my parents, they're responsible for me. Therefore, they're responsible for my education.

OD: And why didn't your dad want you in school? What was...?

JM: What do you mean?

OD: I'm just wondering why you weren't in school.

JM: Because he wan-, because, okay, he wanted help to run his *occupational detail redacted* business.

OD: Right.

JM: They never, I cleaned the house. They never cleaned or did anything like that at all. They were scared that, the place was filthy, and they were scared that social services or someone would come along and find us. I mean, you know, on occasion I did go to school for a short period of time. But it was, you know, I was filthy dirty, I was illiterate. And even...

OD: But it doesn't, it doesn't work like that, you can't just go periodically and hope to, kind of, to learn.

JM: Well it did ... [phone starts ringing/brief interruption]

OD: Okay, so we're just...

JM: What were we talking about?

OD: We've just restarted. That's, yep great.

JM: Oh the, keeping me up to work for him, that's right, yeah.

OD: So it was basically just easier for you to be at home, or he didn't want people to see the state you were in?

JM: He didn't want people to see the state I was in. He didn't want people to know what was going on and, I don't know, maybe someone should ask him why, because I don't, just don't understand why. They were not functional people as human beings, and she was definitely not functional. She went on to have loads of boys, baby boys.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And I think she abused most of them, they were all taken off her and stuff. She was a pretty nasty piece of work.

OD: And do you still have any contact with them?

JM: No, I've had no contact with none of them.

OD: Okay.

JM: Since my, I have a half-sister that asked me if I wanted to see my dad, he was coming to England, donkeys years ago. And I said: "Yeah, without her [JM's step-mother]." But he wouldn't without her because she would never allow it.

OD: So was your dad abusive on his own, or was it only whilst...?

JM: Yeah, he'd hit me. He'd have me by the hair, and up against the door, but I think my dad was, I'm not making excuses, but I think he was in an intolerable situation. He was with a woman that wouldn't let him out of her sight and was insanely jealous and hated me because I looked like my mother. So, yeah, and I think, just, intolerable situation, you know. I mean, my dad was eighteen and my mother sixteen when they had me.

OD: And what happened to your mother? I can't remember, did you say she left?

JM: When I, my mother was, when I was eighteen months old she left. She ran off with a, I think it was a pilot or something; RAF.

OD: And you never saw her again, or...?

JM: Yeah, I traced her in ... my daughter *name redacted* was seven, and she's now forty ... okay. So when she was seven I traced my mother, and we met. And she'd got off with this guy and she'd had two children with him, and I met these two people and they were strangers. And everybody seemed to think it was okay and it was lovely. And it wasn't okay and it wasn't lovely. And my mother became, she came into my life, and suddenly she wanted me to support her, she was nothing like me. But she wanted me to support her, and she was, she'd left her partner and she was, oh, it was just ... And I looked at my little girl who was seven, and I thought you know, I could give my life for that kid. To protect her, to stop her getting any pain. I'd do anything for her. So how my mother could've left me at, at six, in hospital, having had the bone from my nose tore into my brain and having that surgery, a little girl of six, and not even come to see me or made contact; ain't made of the same stuff as me.

OD: No.

JM: No. And I looked at my daughter's name ... and I thought, I couldn't have done that.

OD: No.

JM: So I said to her: "I want nothing to do with you. I've been let down."
Because you can't do that, you can't leave your children.

OD: I think if you've, if you've got a child with you, and you have those feelings, then it probably just made it even stronger that, that...

JM: Yeah, it was the reality that she was the age I was. I was six when I had that. And I thought, a little girl of six having had that happen to her. That's, that's crap, that's...

OD: And you don't fully, you say you don't fully remember what happened, but your, your grandmother...

JM: I, no I don't remember. I remember being in hospital and having my head shaved. I remember my grandmother leaving her handbag, because I couldn't see because I had pads over my eyes, and she left the handbag so I thought she was still there, and obviously she'd gone. I remember them constantly fiddling with my nose, and I was sniffing all the time.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And, so I had this operation. My grandmother told me for years that I had a hole in the bone of my nose and, which was all lies. And when I was later in my, when I was fifteen I went and asked them to straighten it, and they said: "No, no, no, you're a pretty girl, you don't need it straightened." More lies. And then, in my twenties I went to have it straightened, and they x-rayed my head, and they said: "Do you know that you've got plates, metal clips, in your head?" I said: "No." And they explained what had happened. That the bone had gone up and torn right into the brain.

OD: Wow.

JM: And it would be, it would've occurred by a blow to the face. And then I knew, then, that my grandmother had lied to me, and she'd only do that to cover

him up. And I've had to live with that broken nose, and I can't do anything about it and, you know, it's affected my breathing and I snore heavily and stuff like that. Yeah.

OD: And, and being six with this injury, was there anyone around you at that point that was asking questions about why you had that injury?

JM: No, no. And when I tried to pull the records, the social services said the only record that - because the social services pulled my notes - because I said: "I want social services' notes. I wanna know what happened. I want some answers." And all they could find was a record of me being eighteen months old being admitted to hospital for having fallen down the stairs. And eighteen months is about, and then, also, apparently I'd been in, it says that I'd been in a children's home. So, at eighteen months old, when my mother had left...

OD: [Interrupts] They'd put you...

JM: They'd put me in a children's home, and my grandmother had obviously come and got me, with my father.

OD: That's really interesting.

JM: So yeah.

OD: It's such an upsetting story, but you've done so well to, to bring yourself out of what must've been just an unbelievably difficult childhood.

JM: It's a really bad. It's, well, being illiterate and having two little girls at school was horrendous. And then, the best thing was, when I did my *detail

redacted* courses, and she [the tutor] wrote on the, on the thing, 'my goodness, your answers are almost word for word everything I taught.' You know. And at that point it was like, hey, I'm a good, I can do this. And it was like driving a car, you see, because you've got no confidence. You think, I could never do that, then, then I met a girl that had, and I thought I'm quicker than that. I know...

OD: [laughs] No but it's...

JM: If she could do it, I could do it. So, you know. So things like that. And it sort of gives you...

OD: [Interrupts] Well I did a City and Guilds and they're not easy.

JM: No.

OD: ... the writing element of it was quite difficult.

JM: Yeah, I know. And I was a *occupational detail redacted* and I was up in a room in front of fifty people and *detail redacted*, you know, and everything. I did all that. Unfortunately, the love of my life had an affair and left. So, that's just one of those things.

OD: And how long were you together?

JM: Seven years.

OD: Seven years. And he's, your two girls were with him?

JM: No, no, no, no.

OD: Okay.

JM: My two girls were, the first one was with the, the soldier that I met on the ferry, and the second one was another chap that I married. That was a disaster.

OD: And do you think, do you think that this upbringing and this, kind of, the way you've been let down by several different areas of places that were supposed to protect you, and didn't, has that had effects on you and your relationships?

JM: Yeah I'm quite, yeah, I've noticed something, because I've had three marriages, and I notice something about the men I tend to get involved with - because I don't anymore - they all dislike their mothers. Every one of them, there's a common denominator, every one of them has had bad relationships with their mothers. Because somebody said to me: "If you look at all the relationships that you've had and, you know, and you've been married, there's something, a thread, a common thread, and the common thread is they all had bad relationships, didn't like their mothers, didn't respect their mothers." So how could they respect me?

OD: And they maybe have weird ideas about women, or...

JM: Yeah, I yeah, I tend to, it's funny, because I tend to go for well-educated public schoolboys, that's my thing. The last one was a *occupation redacted*. And, yeah, because I'm very, I can adapt to all different situations, a lot of different people, you know.

OD: Yeah definitely.

JM: And things. But yeah, so social services let me down. I have a real problem with authority, I don't like authority. I've always had to work for myself, mainly because, apart from *retailer redacted* - but that was part-time - because I have a condition which is *physical condition redacted*, which is quite severe, and I get a bit tired during the day sometimes and *detail redacted*. I have to sleep, so if I work for myself I can think, okay, I can go and sit in the car and have a, you know.

OD: Yeah.

JM: Or whatever. And, yeah, as I say, now, now I'm, I'm lucky because I have two lovely girls.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And I have four lovely grandchildren so, you know.

OD: I can't believe you're a grandmother.

JM: Yeah, *name redacted* twenty. He's twenty. Oh he's lovely.

OD: Yeah.

JM: He's a good boy. But, you know, so.

OD: But you're, you're now that grandmother for them, you know, you could be, you could be that.

JM: Yes, yeah.

OD: And you could be, maybe...

JM: Oh I don't know, my daughter will tell you I just like to flit off round the world and do my own thing and have a party, she says.

OD: But I think you deserve both, though, don't you? You deserve to be the presence there, you know, because they don't, you know, they've got mothers and they've got supportive parents.

JM: Exactly, yeah.

OD: You're allowed to do both, absolutely.

JM: Yeah, yeah.

OD: So I just have a couple more questions, then, if that's okay.

JM: Yeah that's fine.

OD: So the first one is, so we've talked about your birth, and that you, I think, were clearly let down medically, and perhaps weren't given enough attention to figure out that your baby was breech. Perhaps you weren't monitored enough, like, it seems that, I just want to ask you, and I know this part is probably very upsetting, but you have a, did you say a five day period between giving birth and them telling you that *son's name redacted* had died.

JM: Yes, yes.

OD: I'm just wondering what evidence you ever had that that was the case.

JM: None. None.

OD: Because that's, were you given a certificate, like a birth certificate or anything?

JM: I've got a birth certificate. I can show you, and I've got it and you can take a photograph of it, and I've got a death certificate.

OD: Okay.

JM: But...

OD: But you never saw the body or...?

JM: I think the thing that, you know, when I, over the years different people have said: "Oh, it's not right." So I, I really cannot allow myself to think that anything else happened.

OD: That's...

JM: I would not be able to mentally cope with it.

OD: I don't think that's what I was suggesting. It's more, just, it's, it's very bad practice.

JM: Bad practice? Oh dear...

OD: It's very bad for them to not have, you know, to be provided with documents but for you not to have that opportunity.

JM: Well I think, the thing that's strange is the fact that he was taken, you know, I gave birth and didn't see him. He was gone. It's almost like they stole him from me, you know.

OD: Yeah.

JM: And then he's, I never set eyes on him, and then he's, he's in an incubator, and I'm in *the same location* as well, but I am not allowed to go and see him, or, to see him, or to do anything. But they want me to have him christened, you know so I have to give the ... to have him christened.

OD: And did they make you sign something?

JM: I've no idea.

OD: Okay.

JM: Absolutely no idea.

OD: It's just interest-, I'm just wondering if he was ... were you particularly religious?

JM: No.

OD: Okay, so that was something that the Salvation Army wanted you to do, or...?

JM: I've no idea. I just, one of them, the social worker or somebody said to me, it might've been the hospital, that: "You've gotta christen him because he's very ill."

OD: Yeah. But you weren't present for the christening?

JM: No, no. I never saw him.

OD: That's horrendous

JM: And it's, and, and, and then they expect me to bury him.

OD: Yeah, and they wouldn't let you...

JM: They wouldn't, they physically, two social workers physically restrained me from going near the box, and I wanted to open the box and hold my son. I, and they just wouldn't let me.

OD: And do you think there's...

JM: And then they avoided giving me the grave number, you know. It was just, it was just, the whole thing was...

OD: See, that's what I don't understand, because, I was wondering, maybe if, if they thought some way that it was for your own good that you wouldn't see... And I'm not saying I agree with that.

JM: Well, maybe in those days.

OD: But to me, but to me, then, to not give you the grave number doesn't make sense.

JM: No.

OD: Because I can understand, maybe, you know, you're sixteen, maybe they don't want you to see something that they thought might be harmful or, I can't excuse it at all, but I'm just...

JM: What about the social worker, before he's born, trying to pressurise me into having him adopted.

OD: Yeah, exactly.

JM: You know, it stinks.

OD: Yeah.

JM: The whole thing stinks. But I have the death certificate. So what can I do? If I've got the death certificate, what can I do?

OD: I mean I, I'd, I'm certainly, I don't think there's anything suspicious about it necessarily, it's more that I think you were very badly treated, and that it's important that we record that. And that's why I was asking, I was just trying to figure out if there was some ulterior motive in terms of trying to prevent you from harm in some way. But to not give you a grave number kind of

undermines that, because by that point that's something that could've given you a bit of closure, and you weren't offered that.

JM: Yeah I don't really, I don't really know. I mean [sighs], I don't really know. I mean maybe it's just how they did things. Someone, one of those social workers, made the decision that I would not see my child.

OD: And this is...

JM: And I would love to know who. Who made that decision? How did they come to that decision? Because it's been with me my whole life. I've been tortured by this, the nightmare of the baby, you know. And it's just not fair.

OD: No it's not.

JM: It's just...

OD: But I think what, what that dream sounds like is, that you feel like 'oh, I've forgotten him' or 'I've done...', and that's...

JM: Yes, and then I find him and he's starving.

OD: Yeah, but you, that's such a horrible...

JM: And I, to this day, like, forty years.

OD: But you, you had so little control in that situation.

JM: I had no control.

OD: Yeah, and it's just not, it's not fair, you're right, it's absolutely not fair.

JM: I know, but...

OD: In terms of people at Thorndale...

JM: Yes.

OD: Do you remember the structure at all? Was there a sort of a, you said there was, like, a matron or a brigadier.

JM: Yeah, there was a matron or brigadier or something, brigadiers.

OD: So there so was someone in charge?

JM: Yeah, and she was in charge of the whole thing, yeah.

OD: And were you, you said you were sort of left to yourself?

JM: We were just left to our own devices?

OD: Could you leave?

JM: I was in a dorm, dorm, we could go to the shop and back, yes. I was in a dorm. The first, I think the first few, or whatever, I remember all, lots of girls in lots of beds. And then, just before the baby come, they put us in a room, our own room, with a cot and everything.

OD: Yeah.

JM: For getting ready. And they left me in that bloody room after he was dead as well.

OD: With a cot?

JM: Yeah.

OD: Oh, that's just...

JM: Yeah.

OD: It's so much oversight in ... in ... hell. It's really shocking. Can I ask, when you, when you ... I'm just trying to think my questions ... When you kind of have these full days before you give birth, and before they realise that your baby's breech, what, what do you do to fill your time there?

JM: I made baby clothes.

OD: Ah. Like crochet or knit?

JM: Crochet and knitting and sewing. And actually, when I was at the borstal I made, you know, a blanket out of hexagon shapes, and it was, it was beautiful, it was a big, great big... And the woman who worked there took it.

OD: Ah.

JM: Yeah. And then, when, when I, when I was, to fill my days I just knitted little bomber suits and all sorts of things. I'm very arty like that. And I was preparing for my child, my little, I used to talk to him when I was in the bath and, you know, and I wanted him desperately, and, and then never to have a son in life, it's, it's tough. But they didn't really, they didn't, you'd think they would've prepared us, you know, they would've, oh I don't know, held classes on what to expect.

OD: I think that's something I was very interested in is, is, especially with your age. Because I know that, that some women go into these mother and baby homes in their twenties.

JM: They were older, they were older.

OD: Exactly.

JM: Everybody was older, everybody was older than me.

OD: And perhaps they understand more.

JM: Yeah, everybody was older. Or they had, perhaps, parents that told them what, what to expect and what have you.

OD: Was anyone, were you treated differently at all? So I'm just trying to think if, maybe, there were different ways that the girls in that part, in Thorndale, were treated. Did anyone have preferential treatment? Was everyone...?

JM: We weren't treated at all, we were just given a room...

OD: And that was it?

JM: And fed three times a day.

OD: So there was no...?

JM: They weren't interested in us whatsoever.

OD: So, oh it's very interesting. Okay, so then it was up to you, if you had labour pains, to go and find someone and...

JM: Yeah, you'd have to go and find someone and say, you know: "Look, I'm in pain." And I mean, you know, we had the Army, the British Army, in the evenings. They had high windows and they'd be talking to the troops. You know, where were the bloody Salvation Army women looking after these girls then?

OD: Yeah, because you're still fifteen, sixteen.

JM: Yes.

OD: Yeah, I just, I think you, I think a lot of people who were supposed to support you, didn't, at various stages, and I think that's really important to note down. We'll just, we'll finish in a minute, I just have a couple of questions of, for you.

JM: I've waited long enough for this.

OD: A couple of questions, just for you, that I ask everyone. And I suppose I sort of know the answer, but who do you, who do you blame for, for what happened to you, what, who let you down? Who...?

JM: Social services.

OD: And are they...

JM: Abused me.

OD: Yeah.

JM: My parents abused me, but social services abused me. I mean, for God's sake, when I went to social services and said: "My grandfather's exposing himself to me and I'm frightened. He's a big man", what did they do? They came round and said: "Oh, there's a lock on your door, use it"... [and JM replied] "But it's not happening in the bedroom, it's happening in the lounge."

OD: Yeah.

JM: I mean, that was shit, they should've done something, you know?

OD: Absolutely.

JM: When they ... baby ... when, when I was expecting my baby, they should've, they were my parent, okay? So they should've said: "Okay, well the baby's breech, let's double check this", you know. I was just dumped there.

OD: So I think, in terms of protecting you from abuse, providing you education, providing you adequate healthcare, there's...

JM: The social worker didn't even come and see me after the baby was born.

OD: So what, so you had no further contact with...?

JM: No, no. Until I, I went to the – not that I remember, anyway – I went to stay with that couple, and I had a job in a *detail redacted*, and they came round and said: “No, no, no, you can't, it's, these are not registered child, foster parents. We have to remove you”...

“Well where are you gonna put me?”...

“Well we'll temporarily put you in the borstal until we can find somewhere else.”

... So I was locked up. I mean who, who okayed that?

OD: Yeah.

JM: And that was a, that was a prison. Make no mistake about it, the doors on each landing was locked, the rooms were locked.

OD: And how, how old were the other kids, well, other people in there with you?

JM: Up to twenty I should think, all of us. All girls.

OD: And you were with people who, presumably...

JM: They were fine. I mean, presumably they'd done bad things.

OD: But they weren't violent or anything?

JM: They weren't violent or nasty to me or anything. We were, it was, you know, children, you know, girls, that were... And you had these bloody women that worked there that would just sit back and do nothing, order us about. We were allowed to have, they were allowed to have cigarettes, they would dish out a couple of cigarettes if you were good, and stuff like that. Yeah, yeah.

OD: And where, I know you can't remember, but do you have any memories at all about what this borstal was or where it was or...

JM: No, I can't. When I spoke to the social worker, she said to me that she had an idea. I can give you her details if you like, and you can ask her. But I, I'll get it, it's on my pad. She, she had an idea [JM leaves the room and rummages around] ... [from another room] of where it would be. [JM returns to the room] It just amazes me that records are destroyed and then nobody knows what the hell's going on.

OD: I think it's just, it's alarming that you can't, that someone can't give you, just, that information at least, of where you spent part of your life.

JM: No, I know. Let's see if I can find out. She did say Belfast to me [so probably Whiteabbey Training School].

OD: Where did your parents live in *location redacted*, was it...?

JM: *Name of road redacted*, that's where my grandmother lived. [pause while JM reads notes] Okay, *reads out name of social worker and her work location*...

OD: And how old is *social worker's name redacted*, do you know?

JM: I don't know. I've never met her, I've only ever spoken to her on the phone.

OD: But is she, is she someone who works there now?

JM: Yeah this was, this was 2013 the last time I had contact with her, because I was trying to get her to dig up anything she could about the baby and what have you, and what had happened.

OD: Okay, interesting. I'm just wondering if she worked, if she had worked there in the seventies.

JM: No, no. But she knew, when I spoke to her she said, you know, she sort of knew where the home would've been.

OD: Okay, interesting.

JM: But it's just, it's beyond belief to me. It's beyond belief to me that social services don't have records, where are all the records gone?

OD: Yeah, definitely.

JM: I mean, they should have records of what they did with people, you know.

OD: Absolutely. Okay, so that's really great that we've got that noted down. The last question, then, is, what made you, I know that we, you posted on the Belfast Forum, I think, is how we originally started talking.

JM: Yes.

OD: But what, what would you like to see from an inquiry about this? Why did you want to give your...?

JM: Because if it turns out that they took my son, or anything comes of this, I'd like the grave exhumed and I'd like a DNA to prove that he's my child. That that baby's in there. Because there's always that question mark.

OD: So if, if, when we hand this all over to health and social services, and, so you're saying that you, you weren't given enough information and you would like that information to come out.

JM: I want, yeah, I want to know that that was my baby that I buried, that he is in there, and I wanna hold him. So I know it'll be bones in a box, but I want a DNA to prove that's my child, and I wanna hold him.

[Pause in conversation]

OD: That's really, I'm, I think it's heart-breaking, but it's a very important thing to have put down onto the record that we can, I mean, we'll pass everything on, and all we can do is try and get these stories, kind of, to them. And I hope that you get something from that.

JM: Well I think, I think the care was atrocious, there wasn't any care. And they make excuses: "Oh, it was the time of the Troubles. Oh this was happening and that was happening." It's no excuse.

OD: No.

JM: No excuse. And, you know, someone somewhere decided I wouldn't see my son. And that's what I, I just can't get my head round that.

OD: What hospital were you in, can you remember?

JM: *Hospital name redacted*

OD: Okay. Do you have anything else you'd like to say while we have the tape on? I think you've done a pretty fantastic job of chronologically taking me through your story, but if there is anything else you'd like to say.

JM: I didn't want it to be ...

OD: There isn't any pressure, but it's just to give you the chance to say what you want.

JM: Yeah, I think that, I think that if there's anybody else that ever listens to this and they have a, they're having a bad time or a bad childhood or anything like that, I think that, absolutely, the thing to do, is not to dwell on it. Because I know other people that dwell, and they go back. I mean, I have a half-sister, she goes back to Ireland, she tries to have a father. But he's never gonna be that, it upsets her, drags her down and makes her depressed, okay?

OD: Yeah.

JM: I think that you, if you have the strength to just say: “They’re nothing to do with me” and look forward. Don’t look back.

OD: Yeah.

JM: You know.

OD: And I think you’re a massive example of that, because you, you’ve created...

JM: Always forward.

OD: I think you’ve created what you, what you didn’t have, and I think you have so much to be proud of, post what happened to you, that I think that is quite an inspirational thing to say.

JM: Yeah, I mean my daughter has met the rest of the family, she’s met my half-sister and everything. And she just says to me: “Mum, my God, they’ve all got arthritis, they’re all alcoholics, they’re all, you know.” She said “and you are just different. Diff-, you’re nothing like these people.”

OD: Look at all the places that you’ve been and all the things that you’ve done.

JM: Yeah, and I have a, yeah I have a...

OD: But you’ve done that whilst still building a family.

JM: I've done that that myself, I've done that for myself.

OD: Yeah, you've done both of those.

JM: That's the other thing, I haven't, I've never got any money for the marriages or anything like that, I've done everything for myself, on my own two feet.

OD: Yeah, absolutely.

JM: And, yeah, and I sort of woke up one day in the cottage and thought, I had a cottage on farmland, I had veg beds and a secret garden and all sorts, and it was lovely, and I just woke up one morning and thought, I can't do it anymore, my neck and my shoulder are bad. Because so much, so much gardening and stuff. And I'm just a doer, and I just gave the keys to an agent and packed a case and got on a plane and went to *overseas location* for six months, or three months, and did yoga, and then came back and sold the cottage and met *name redacted*, married him, that didn't last very long. And he was, yeah, he was a nice guy but he used to drink so much and, you know. Anyway, that went up the Swanee. But I'd sort of made my money, so I'm not waiting, I've got my *employer's name redacted* pension money through, which is great. So, you know, I'm...

OD: I think you can enjoy this time.

JM: I can, I'm not, I haven't got a lot of money but I'm, I don't have to go to work.

OD: No.

JM: And that's the...

OD: That's the key thing.

JM: But I can't, because my *physical condition redacted*. But I've never signed on, you see. I've never.

OD: No, but now you get to...

JM: Yeah.

OD: I know it's...

JM: Well this is, compared to the other houses I had, this is better. This is just, my daughter said: "You have to stop fishing about and you have to buy a little bungalow near me so that, when you get older, I can", you know, "you're near me." Because, you know, "and we can be together and I can look after you and everything." And I was thinking, oh, really? But yeah, but I'm just ... Yeah, I can't ... anybody else, you see, would've signed on. But I got the money for the bungalow so I couldn't anyway, and I wouldn't anyway. So I stayed on, stayed on my own two feet.

OD: So I think that's a really good message, like, to – like we were saying.

JM: Don't dwell on the past. Don't dwell on what they did to you. Don't dwell on what these idiots affect ... how these idiots affected your life. Obviously, the baby thing, that does, it'll never go away and it does affect me.

OD: Yep.

JM: But, and I get desperately upset about it. And, but you know, I'll tell you a lovely thing.

OD: Okay, please do.

JM: When my daughter *name redacted* was having her son, she was having a baby, and she said: "We're gonna have a girl, we're gonna have a girl." And when she went into labour we were all at the hospital, and her sister was there and I was there and her husband was there, and the baby was coming. Just before the birth she said: "I'm not doing this, I'm going home", she said "I've changed my mind, this is a road too far!" And just before she gave birth I had to leave the room because I couldn't bear to see her in that pain. And my son-in-law come out and he said: "You've got a little grandson. We'll let you name him."

OD: Aw.

JM: And I called him *name redacted*, after *actor's name redacted*. Get him a nice strong name, and I held him. The bond with that baby was, yeah, that was something else, because...

OD: That's lovely.

JM: There was this love that flowed. Anybody that's had a child, they understand that. The moment of birth you have this... When you're a grandparent it's like a double-whammy. But then they let me call him *name redacted*.

OD: That's, that's really lovely.

JM: Yeah. That's the really lovely...

OD: It's a great name too, but...

JM: Yeah, so I got my little boy in the end, eh?

OD: Yeah you did. And I think, I think that that's a really special thing to have shared with me, I really appreciate that. But that's a really lovely...

JM: Well it's something lovely that my daughter did for me.

OD: Yeah, and for you to have that chance again to bond, and I think that's really important.

JM: Yeah, and he's a lovely boy.

OD: And he's twenty?

JM: He was twenty on Wednesday. I know, I know, he's gorgeous. I said to him, "where did you get those shoulders from?" Because he goes to the gym, he's a very good boy. Very bright, doing *detail redacted*. He's, he's, oh he's...

OD: Is he at university?

JM: No, he's just at the local college. But he's, he's, yeah he's, he's, oh he loves cars, oh god, a cars' man. But no, he'll do really well in life.

OD: Yeah.

JM: Because on his birthday card I put 'you're a chip off the old block', you know.

OD: That's really lovely.

JM: But anyway.

OD: Okay.

JM: So yeah, there you have it. Let's hope that something comes of it all eh?

OD: That's what I hope, let me...

[END OF INTERVIEW]